INDIA'S LIVESTOCK SECTOR

Initiatives, Impact, and Future Prospects

INTRODUCTION

India's livestock sector is the backbone of its rural economy. Livestock sector plays a multifaceted role in providing livelihood support to the rural population. Livestock sector apart from contributing to national economy in general and to agricultural economy in particular also provides employment generation opportunities, asset creation, coping mechanism against crop failure and social and financial security.



Livestock production systems in India are mostly based on low cost agricultural residues, agro- byproducts and traditional technologies, primarily for the production of milk, draft power, meat, egg, fiber etc. About 100 million rural household own livestock of one species or the other and 80 million among them own cattle and / or buffaloes. The livestock sector, besides contributing to the national economy, plays a key role in providing livelihoods to 80 million rural households. In the rural areas, most of the livestock rearing activities are handled by women. As many as 75 million women are engaged in livestock sector as against 15 million men. There is an increasing trend towards participation of women in livestock development activities. This has led to empowerment of women-headed households in the rural communities.

Importance of Animal husbandry in rural economy can also be understood from the fact that the land in our country is not equitably distributed among the farmers whereas more than 90% of the dairy animals are with small, marginal and landless labourers and 12-26% of the rural household income comes from the Animal Husbandry and dairying sector.

Low capital investment, short operating cycle, and steady returns make Animal Husbandry a preferred livelihood activity among rural households. Animal Husbandry also acts as a cushion by minimising agriculture losses at the time of environmental adversities like floods and droughts.

The large network of dairy cooperatives has helped in providing market access to millions of dairy farmers as they integrate and empower our dairy farmers. The dairy cooperatives in the country pay back more than 70 percent of the consumer rupee to the milk producers, which is the highest in the World. Milk and milk products are important constituents of Indian thali, consumed by more than 75 percent of the households and about 20 percent of total food expenditure is spent on milk & milk products.

CONTRIBUTION OF LIVESTOCK SECTOR TO NATIONAL ECONOMY

Livestock Sector is an important subsector of agriculture in the Indian economy. It grew at a CAGR of 12.77 per cent during 2014-15 to 2023-24 (at constant prices). As per the estimates of National Accounts Statistics (NAS) 2025 for sector wise GVA of agriculture and allied sectors, the contribution of livestock in total agriculture and allied sector GVA (at constant prices) has increased from 24.32 per cent (2014-15) to 31 per cent (2022-23). Livestock sector contributed 5.5 per cent of total GVA in 2022-23. Development of livestock sector has led to improvement in per capita availability of milk, eggs and meat. Value of output of livestock sector is 18.99 lakh crore at current price during 2022-23 (as per National Account Statistics 2025). Value of output of milk alone is more than Rs.12.77 lakh crore (67% of the total value of output of livestock sector) which is the highest of the agriculture produce and even more than the combined value of Paddy and Wheat.

GROWTH IN DAIRY SECTOR

India is global leader in milk production contributing